LECTURE 6: READING SKILLS

Definition

A simple (and provisional) definition of reading is that it is a process whereby one looks at and understands what has been written. This definition of reading does not mean that one needs to understand everything in a text. Understanding is not an "all or nothing" process and from that it follows that reading is not "all or nothing" process either. Reading involves many sub skills for example-literal comprehension, inferential comprehension, interpretation, evaluation and critical appreciation. The process of reading has the following characteristics.

1. It is both a physical and mental activity.

2. It requires attention and thought.

3. It involves the participation of the reader emotionally and intellectually.

4. It involves interpretation of the written (printed) symbols.

Different readers may interpret the same text differently. This implies that readers put meaning into what they read. The meaning that a reader may put on a piece of writing is determined by several factors. For example, the reader's background, knowledge or experience, emotional appeal of the subject or the reader's intellectual ability.

Reading is a very versatile activity because it can take place almost anywhere: in a classroom, library, house, vehicle, train etc.

Purposes for reading

a) Reading for pleasure/entertainment

b) Acquiring knowledge and information: to be informed about the world you live in.

c) Reading for academic purpose

Materials that can be read for academic information are: textbooks, reference books, general and specialist journals, magazines and special sections of newspapers.

d) Reading for instructions or directions: food and clothing labels, instructions on drugs, operational manuals on machines etc.

Types of Reading

There are several types/ways/techniques of reading. They are previewing, skimming, scanning, word for word reading, light reading, intensive/study/critical reading and extensive reading.

a) Previewing

It involves looking over a text to determine its relevance and worth for a specific reading purpose. It helps the reader to predict in a very short time, what a reading text is all about and to determine its degree of relevance. You then can decide whether to read the book or not, or whether to read a part or parts of it and which part.

Previewing a text is done by looking at the following:

i) Front matter: title, forward/preface or introduction, table of contents.

ii) Back matter: blurbs, index, glossary, bibliography.

iii) The book itself: Headings, subheadings, organizations, language, content, diagrams.

b) Skimming

Used when a reader wants to get the main idea or gist of a text within a very short time. When skimming, you need to read the topic sentences only. The topic sentence is usually the first in a paragraph and expresses the main idea. But sometimes a writer may choose to make the second sentence of a paragraph the topic sentence. On rare occasions, a writer may make the last sentence of the paragraph the topic sentence. This is determined by the writing style that a writer may adapt to convey certain information. You can skim through a long text or even a book in just a few minutes and get the gist of the text.

c) Scanning

It involves searching for particular items of information. You are interested in these items only and not everything in the text.

d) Word by word reading;

This reading technique is used when one is learning how to read for the first time. You might use this technique if you decide to learn a new language. Word for word reading means trying to understand fully one word or phrase at a time. It is a slow reading technique. Scientists and mathematicians use it when they are studying processes and formulae.

e) Light reading

This is the way most people read most of the time. There is neither an attempt to digest the material that is read nor is there any attempt to assess it critically. This type of reading tends to be fast and superficial. It is the type of reading most people apply when reading newspapers and novels. This kind of reading is not recommended for study purposes but you can use the technique when reading for leisure.

f) Intensive reading

Intensive reading entails content study of what is read in some detail and study of language in which the material is written. Intensive reading calls for a deep and thorough understanding of what is written. The concern is with detailed comprehension of short texts-typically not more than five hundred words in length. Intensive reading implies approaching a text under the guidance of a task (or a teacher) which forces the student to use analytical, critical and evaluative skills. It is the type of reading a university student engages in when studying.

To be an efficient intensive reader, you need to get rid of some bad reading habits:

i) Trying to understand every word that you read by consulting the dictionary from time to time. Slows down reading and interferes with concentration.

ii) Vocalization or moving lips as you read. This slows down reading to a speaking pace and is therefore inefficient.

iii) Retrogression. This means reading forwards and backwards. It hinders comprehension unless you are doing word by word reading.

iv) Pointing - using a finger, pencil or pen over what is being read or nodding the head. This is not only slow but also clumsy

g) Extensive Reading

Extensive reading might be said to emphasize the process whereby a student comes to understand a book without fully grasping every point of it, or even trying to. Strategies such as skimming and scanning are important here, but there are also others such as recognising the contribution of 'plot' or 'argument' to understanding a text. Extensive reading usually involves long texts or books with many pages - or just wide reading. The objectives of extensive reading are: to promote enjoyment of reading, to provide various experiences, and to provide wide exposure to written English in use.

TEXT READABILITY

This is the extent to which it is possible to read a text and comprehend its content. It refers to the relative simplicity or difficulty in understanding, interpreting, evaluating or applying the information in a text.

Factors determining text readability

a) The language level.

This includes new words and other technical or scientific terms which one is not familiar with It may also refer to sentence structures, stylistic devices, register, idiomatic expressions used etc.

b) Content

This refers to the subject matter. It could be elementary or advanced depending on the level of education of the reader.

c) Layout

This is the arrangement or structure of the text in terms of chapters, units, paragraphs and even sentences. The way a text is structured makes it possible to follow the trend of though of the writer.

d) Print size

The size of the print, the front size are also important factors. Very small print is uncomfortable and tiring to read.

How to improve your comprehension during reading:

a) Vocabulary

Begin from what you already know (activating prior knowledge)

One can understand new words, difficult terms, phrases or expressions without using a dictionary. This can be done by: -looking at the context clues, getting synonyms, using predictions and using inference

b) Predictions

This is when one reads to confirm expectations. Predict and think about what will happen next in the text, or how your questions will be answered. This technique is highly motivating and gives one a purpose for reading.

c) Inference/implications ("reading between the lines")

This is 'reading' beyond what you can see in print, on pages. It calls for reasoning, reaching an opinion, making conclusions. It is important when answering questions on meanings of words, phrases as used in the passage and also identification of the connotations of different sentences. Always try to make sense of what you are reading (context).

Know that as a good reader you often REREAD parts of, or even, the whole text two or more times in order to make sense of what you are reading.

1. Ask yourself questions; before, during and after reading.

Read with a purpose. Know why you are reading and what you are reading to find out.

THE SQ3R READING STRATEGY

What is SQ3R?

This is a flexible reading strategy that engages the reader during each phase of the reading process. The abbreviation SQ3R stands for the steps that one reader follows while using this method of reading. These are: Survey, Question, Read, Revise and Review.

In this strategy, readers preview/SURVEY (S)the text material to develop predictions and set the purpose for the reading by generating QUESTIONS (about the topic. They READ actively, searching for answers to those questions. They monitor their comprehension as they summarize WRITE& RECITE. Finally, they evaluate their comprehension through REVIEW activities.

Two general learning components must be addressed as you begin the reading process and the SQ3R method will activate them:

First, place the reading in CONTEXT. What is the reading about and do you have any prior knowledge about this subject to help you extract the meaning that you are looking for? The SURVEY and SYSTEMATIC reading puts this process into motion. You get an overview that will "jog your memory" as you search for prior knowledge on the subject. Ask questions about what you don't know. Make the questions simple and general if you don't have much prior knowledge and more specific if this is an area of study that is familiar to you. Using these questions will guide your speed and comprehension as you attempt to answer them. Remember, the student that is engaged in reading is motivated,

Let us now look at how we can use the SQ3R method in comprehending texts.

NB: stages 3 and 4 should enable you to make good notes.

How to Use SQ4R

1. **Survey what you are about to read**

- Systematic Reading
- Think about the title: What do you know about this subject?
- What do I want to know?
- Glance over headings and/skim the first sentences of paragraphs.
- Look at illustrations and graphic aids.
- Read the first paragraph.
- Read the last paragraph or summary.

2. **Question ie Turn the title and sub-titles into WH-element question.**

This becomes the major purpose for your reading.

- Write down any questions that come to mind during the survey.
- Turn headings into questions.
- Turn subheadings, illustrations, and graphic aids into questions.
- Write down unfamiliar vocabulary and determine the meaning.

3. Read Actively
- Read to search for answers to the questions set.
- Respond to objectives and use context clues for unfamiliar words.
- React to unclear passages, confusing terms, and questionable statements by generating additional questions.

4. Write and Recite
- Look away from the answers and the book to recall what was read.
- Recite answers to the questions aloud or in writing.
- Reread text for unanswered questions.
- Reread or skim to locate and prove your points.
- Write down the key terms and ideas in outline form.
- Always read/question/recite before marking or taking down notes.
- Check yourself against the text. Correct and add to your answer.

5. Review
- Answer the major purpose questions.
- Look over answers and all parts of the chapter to organize the information.
- Summarize the information learned by creating a graphic organizer (concept map) that depicts the main ideas, by drawing a flow chart, by writing a summary,
- You can also summarize by participating in a group discussion, or by writing an explanation of how this material has changed your perceptions or applies to your life.

READING NON-LINEAR TEXTS

Non-linear texts include charts, diagrams, graphs, tables, figures etc. In academic writing, data is frequently presented by means of non-linear texts. In writing essays or term papers, the use of graphs and charts can make your work more attractive, interesting and informative.

i) Tables

This is one of the most straight ways of presenting information, although not necessarily the easiest to interpret. The data can be used to make certain conclusions, comparisons and summaries.

ii) Bar graphs

This is the simplest kind of graph to interpret. It is usually very visual with various colours or shading to give a quick overall picture to the reader. They are mainly suitable when comparing and contrasting two or more groups. The bar graphs should be drawn proportionally and should be accurate.

-There can be more than one set of figures represented in one bar graph. In this case, the key should indicate proper colours used to distinguish sets of information.

iii)Histograms

The term histogram is often incorrectly interchanged with bar graph, but there is some difference. Histograms are often used to show frequency of occurrence, or to show how common something is over a given range. (e.g. time). They are commonly used in the representation of annual rainfall or temperature for a country or town. Here, the divisions will be conveniently twelve for the months and will enable the reader to make instant comparisons, even before studying actual numbers on the axes.

iv) Pie charts

Mainly suitable when showing the difference among various types of things or groups. The various measures are given either in degrees or percentages.

v) Line graphs

These are suitable when the information given (or being represented) doesn't require comparison and contrast. The information only shows how particular figures are represented (particularly if there's fluctuation). However, comparison and contrasts are possible when there is more than one line graph in one representation. These are called **combination graphs** and involve the superimposition of one on another using the same axis or axes. They save space and also enable the reader to immediately compare one set of figures with another.

vi) Pyramids

These are very useful when comparing and contrasting two sets of figures; for example, the male and the female at a given time.

-The pyramid has two sets of figures being compared or contrasted, put in the same diagram e.g. one on the left, the other on the right.

Interpretation of non-linear texts:

The following points are important in the analysis/interpretation of non-linear texts.

i) the key

ii) the scale used

iii) the proper representation of the texts e.g. the X and Y axes for graphs.

iv) Labeling the texts accurately and correctly

v) Critical reading/interpretation ie. Using inference and implication and making comments on what you can interpret from texts.

vi) A summary of important information and comments covering the whole te